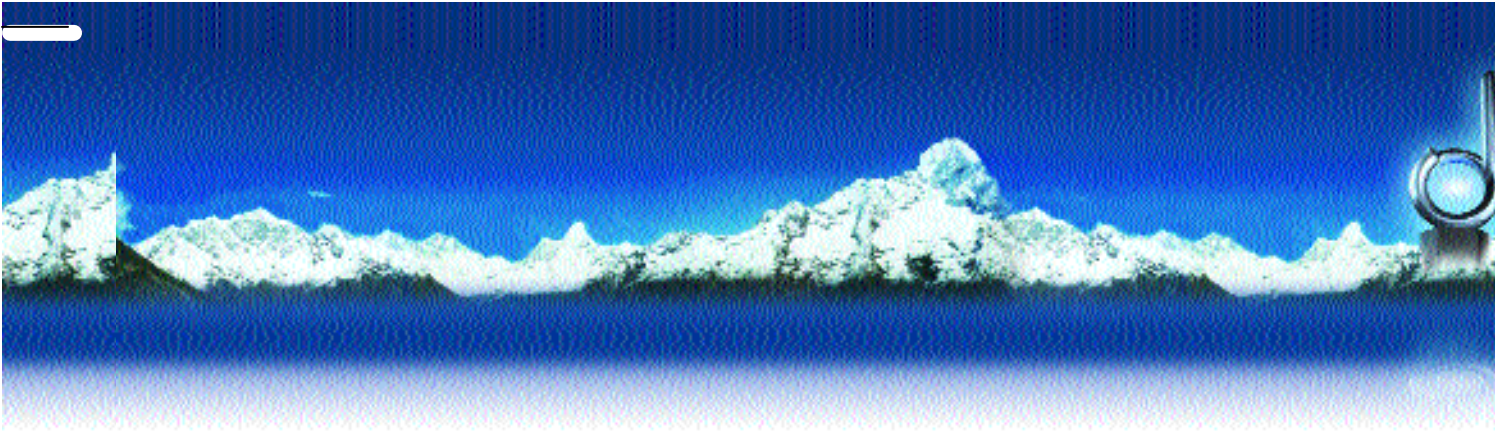
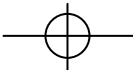




MP3 PLAYERS

When MP3 players first came out, the very thought of carrying along a part of your 500-track MP3 collection sent a surge of excitement through every audiophile's spine. The primary components that these devices are built around a signal processor to decode the MP3 tracks and Flash memory to store the tracks. Since these ingredients accounted for a major portion of the cost of the player, acceptance was not very high initially. However, with the drop in Flash memory prices over the latter half of this year, MP3 players are coming closer to every music lover.

Hear the right notes

MP3 players are characterised by the features they support in a given form factor and by their price tags. Also, since they are meant to be used while on the move—while exercising, commuting or walking—the effective audio quality of most MP3 players hardly differs. It is only when the audio signal is closely scrutinised that differences begin to emerge. However, these differences are too minute to be noticed when these devices are used in everyday situations. Therefore, one of the most important considerations in buying an MP3 player is the number of features they offer in a given size. Also, look for an intuitive navigation system that lets you locate and play your tracks quickly and easily. The controls of the player should also be easily accessible and the bundled software must be easy to understand and work with.

Enhancements to digital audio codecs and standards keep emerging and it is therefore important that your player has robust driver support on the company Web site for newer digital audio formats.

Arguably, the most important component of an MP3 player is its storage system and capacity. Since the MP3 player is meant for being used while on the move, it is important that you have enough room for your songs. Most entry-level MP3 players come with 32 MB of memory and this can store about 30 minutes of near-CD quality audio. Therefore, it is recommended that you choose one with at least 64 MB of memory—the more the merrier. Also, if you happen to have another device with Flash memory, such as a digital camera, go for an MP3 player that supports a similar format of memory so that you can exchange memory between the two devices. If price is not a bar, then the best you can opt for when it comes to storing all your songs would be an MP3 player that features a hard disk drive in it—these are available in capacities ranging from 8 GB all the way up to 40 GB and

Nominees		
Name	Contacts	Comments
Creative DAP-CD0001	Compuage Infocom Ltd Ph: 022-23842200	Capable of reading CDs, CD-RWs, this MP3 Audio CD supports ID3 tags and boasts a variety of song control features
Napa DAV316	Moon Computers Ph: 022-22653390	Capable of reading CDs, CD-RWs, this MP3 Audio CD features NiMH batteries and ID3 tag support

at their highest capacity, can store audio equivalent to 2,000 CDs worth of music!

If you want reasonable storage capacity but are on a budget, CD-MP3 players are your best bet. With the ability to store about 120 songs on a single CD, they are a good solution compared to solid state and hard disk based MP3 players. In all, this genre of MP3 players are the most inexpensive.

When on the road, another very important factor to consider in a portable device is power—you have to have enough power to run it through your journey. Look for an MP3 player that has a long battery life and one that uses an easily accessible battery format such as the AA batteries.

There should also be an adequate number of playback modes for your tracks such as looping, repeat, and programmed play. Look out for players that offer special support for digital audio playback on the player itself—an MP3 player that has a graphic equaliser or specialised bass and treble controls with preset audio profiles is preferred.

Finally, since you might have to carry your MP3 player around with you, make sure that it is comfortable to hold and navigate through. CD and hard disk MP3 players are larger in size and also involve moving parts that could be prone to damage due to rough treatment or physical shock. Therefore, if you are going to tag your MP3 player along for your workout or morning jog, it would be a good idea to opt for a solid state MP3 player as it will be significantly more robust compared to other kinds.

And the award goes to...

The MP3 player that wins this year is the Creative PA-20. On account of its great audio performance, a small size and superior audio quality, this MP3 player is built around a very small form factor, this MP3 player offers superior audio quality and the ability to support MP3 and WMA formats, in addition to the range of audio control features such as shuffle and programmed playback.



Creative PA-20
Compuage Infocom Ltd,
Ph: 022-23842200

The verdict: This little player

packs plenty of performance into a very small package. With 32 MB of memory and support for formats such as MP3 and WMA, this MP3 player is the ideal companion during those morning jogs

